The Nihilist Who Cannot Escape Morality

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The Question Behind the Denial

There is something intriguing about the assertion that objective moral values do not exist.

Not necessarily because the assertion is wrong, nor because it is particularly difficult to defend, but because of what happens when someone makes it.

The person making that assertion takes a position. They distinguish between what they consider objective and subjective, between what can be established and what remains dependent on human interpretation. They apply criteria, draw distinctions, and arrive at a conclusion concerning the nature of morality.

In other words, they give meaning to what they observe.

This is an observation about the position from which the objection to objective morality is made.

Moral nihilism, particularly in its philosophical rather than popular interpretation, does not necessarily claim that human beings have no values. It questions whether moral values possess an objective validity independent of those who hold them. A moral nihilist can care deeply about others, act responsibly, and live according to principles without considering those principles universally or objectively binding.

That distinction deserves respect. Without it, the discussion would be over before it had properly begun.

And yet, something remains worth examining.

If denying objective morality requires a perspective, and a perspective involves values, what exactly has been removed by the denial?

Perspective and the Presence of Value

We rarely encounter the world without some frame of reference. What attracts our attention, what we consider relevant, and how we understand what we encounter are influenced by the position from which we look.

This does not mean that reality is merely a product of interpretation. It means that our understanding of reality takes shape through perspectives, and that those perspectives may differ without the underlying object necessarily changing.

Consider a seemingly straightforward concept such as efficiency.

We can measure how much energy a process consumes, how long it takes, or how many resources it requires. These measurements may be established independently of anyone's preference for the outcome.

But when we describe that process as efficient, we introduce a relationship between those measurements and something else. A purpose, an expectation, a comparison, or a criterion against which the result is understood.

Efficiency does not explain itself.

A process that minimises costs may be efficient from a financial perspective and less desirable from an environmental one. A procedure that saves time may increase risk. A system that optimises resource consumption may do so at the expense of resilience.

None of these perspectives needs to be dismissed. Each brings something into view, and each may leave something else outside its immediate field of attention.

What matters here is that value is already involved in the way the phenomenon is understood, before anyone needs to declare the outcome good or bad.

That brings us to an important distinction, one that is easily overlooked when discussing morality.

Value Does Not Pass Judgement

We often speak about moral values as though they were judgements waiting to be expressed. We associate fairness with what is fair, responsibility with what is responsible, and justice with what is just.

Yet the existence of a value and the judgement made through that value are not the same thing.

Two people may both value fairness and disagree profoundly about what fairness requires in a particular situation. Their disagreement does not necessarily concern the existence of the value. It may concern its interpretation, its relationship to other values, or the circumstances in which it is applied.

The same applies to responsibility, freedom, security, and countless other values through which people understand their world.

A value does not independently decide what should happen. It does not condemn, approve, or act. Those activities belong to whoever engages with it.

Morality may be present in value. The judgement belongs to the person working with that value, not to the value itself.

This distinction changes the direction of the discussion.

If morality is understood exclusively through explicit judgements about right and wrong, then its presence becomes dependent on someone making such a judgement. But if moral dimensions can already be present within the values that inform a perspective, morality need not wait for a judgement to become relevant.

There is a qualification worth making. Not every value is necessarily moral in the conventional philosophical sense. We distinguish between aesthetic preferences, practical considerations, standards of knowledge, and moral commitments for good reasons.

Nevertheless, the existence of those distinctions does not establish that the categories are always independent of one another. Practical efficiency can be connected to responsibility. Aesthetic preferences can reflect cultural expectations. Standards of evidence can be associated with intellectual honesty.

Whether a moral dimension is present in any particular case remains something to investigate, rather than something to assume.

What the Nihilist Actually Denies

With this distinction in mind, we can return to moral nihilism without reducing it to a position it does not hold.

The philosophical nihilist may argue that there are no objective moral facts. Moral statements, on this account, do not describe truths that exist independently of human perspectives.

That is a serious philosophical position. It addresses the status of moral claims rather than necessarily denying the human experience of moral concern.

The difficulty arises when we move from the denial of objective moral validity to the suggestion that morality itself has somehow been left behind.

These are different claims.

To say that moral values have no objective foundation is not to say that values are absent. Nor does it mean that the person making the claim has ceased to interpret the world through a perspective.

The nihilist still distinguishes, reasons, evaluates arguments, and determines what constitutes sufficient grounds for accepting or rejecting a proposition.

Truth, consistency, evidence, and justification may all play a role in that reasoning. These are commonly understood as epistemic rather than moral values, and it would be careless to declare them moral simply because they are values.

But it would be equally careless to assume that their use places the person employing them entirely outside the domain of moral consideration.

That is precisely what deserves examination.

The denial of objective morality does not, by itself, establish the absence of morality within the perspective from which the denial is made.

A nihilist may readily acknowledge the presence of human values while continuing to reject their objective moral authority.

The point is more fundamental, and perhaps more modest: the existence of moral phenomena and the objective validity attributed to them are different questions. Answering one does not automatically settle the other.

The Ought That Remains

There is one place where the denial reaches further than it may intend.

To reject objective morality, the nihilist relies on norms of reasoning. A claim ought to be supported by evidence. An argument ought to be consistent. A conclusion ought to follow from its premises. Where these conditions are not met, the claim ought to be rejected.

These norms are not presented as preferences. The nihilist does not suggest that consistency is merely a matter of taste, or that evidence matters only to those who happen to value it. The norms are treated as binding on anyone who takes part in the discussion, including those who disagree.

That is a strong position. It holds that some reasons apply to us whether we acknowledge them or not.

It is also the kind of authority the nihilist denies to morality.

The structure is the same in both cases. A moral claim says that someone ought to act in a certain way. An epistemic norm says that someone ought to believe in a certain way. Both describe what is required of a person, independent of what that person happens to want.

If the second can be binding, the question is why the first cannot.

The nihilist may reject the authority of the moral ought. What requires explanation is why the ought of reasoning is retained.

There may be answers to that question. Some argue that epistemic norms are instrumental, binding only on those who aim at truth. Others hold that the two kinds of ought differ in ways that have yet to be made explicit. These positions deserve examination.

But they must be given. The denial of objective morality cannot be made from a place where normativity is absent, because the denial itself depends on it.

That is where escape becomes difficult. Not in the presence of values, but in the authority the nihilist requires in order to make the denial at all.

The Observer Is Also Present

There is another aspect of this discussion that deserves attention.

When we examine a perspective, we tend to concentrate on what it tells us about its object. We ask whether the claim is true, whether the reasoning is sound, and whether the conclusion follows from the evidence.

Those are legitimate questions. But the perspective itself is also present.

Its assumptions, distinctions, criteria, and values can become objects of examination in their own right.

The nihilist examining morality is therefore not absent from the examination. The nihilist's perspective is part of what can be observed, just as the perspective of someone defending objective moral truth can be observed.

Neither position needs to be privileged simply because it is the one doing the examining.

This does not mean that every perspective is equally well supported, or that contradictory claims must somehow be reconciled. Different perspectives may reveal different aspects of an object, and they may remain in tension even after their grounds have been made explicit.

That tension need not be treated as a failure.

It may be precisely where further understanding becomes possible.

An observation can be established without requiring immediate agreement about its meaning. A value can be recognised without being endorsed. A judgement can be examined without being adopted.

The possibility of making these distinctions allows us to investigate morality without first having to decide which moral position should prevail.

Before the Judgement

Much of the philosophical debate about morality concerns its foundations. Does moral truth exist independently of human beings? Is it constructed through social relationships? Does it arise from reason, emotion, experience, or some combination of these?

These questions have occupied philosophers for centuries, and there is little reason to expect a single observation to settle them.

But there is another place from which to begin.

Before asking whether a moral claim is objectively true, we can ask what is actually present.

There are people who hold values. There are perspectives through which those values acquire meaning. There are interpretations, disagreements, convictions, and judgements. There are also people who deny that any of these establish an objective moral truth.

All of these are available for examination.

Recognising their presence does not require us to endorse them, and examining their relationships does not require us to assign them a moral ranking.

It requires us to distinguish what is being observed from the meaning attributed to it, and the meaning attributed to it from the judgement subsequently made.

This is not a method for escaping morality. It is a way of approaching moral questions without allowing our own judgement to determine in advance what we are prepared to see.

And perhaps that distinction matters more than it initially appears.

The Nihilist Remains in the Conversation

We can now return to the person who began by denying the existence of objective moral values.

The nihilist has not necessarily contradicted themselves. They may have made a perfectly coherent claim about the absence of objective moral facts.

But they have also taken a position, employed a perspective, and participated in the very discourse whose foundations they question.

That participation leaves open the possibility that moral dimensions are present within the values informing their perspective, regardless of whether they recognise those dimensions as objectively valid.

And this is where the distinction between value and judgement becomes decisive.

If morality can reside within value, then refusing to pronounce a moral judgement does not necessarily remove morality from the perspective. Equally, denying the objective validity of moral values does not make the values through which one reasons disappear.

The nihilist may reject the objective authority of morality. That is a position worthy of serious consideration.

What the nihilist cannot establish through that rejection alone is that morality has ceased to be present.

There is no need to turn this into a victory over nihilism. The philosophical question remains open, and the distinction between the existence of moral phenomena and their objective validity remains intact.

Perhaps the more useful outcome is that we no longer have to confuse the presence of morality with the judgement someone makes about it.

A perspective may contain values. Those values may contain moral dimensions. And the person engaging with them remains responsible for the interpretation and judgement that follow.

The values are there to be examined, whether we agree with them or not.

Before deciding what something ought to be, we might first understand what is.

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